

Glossary

Action
The method of loading and/or firing a gun.

Active Protection System (APS)
A method of defeating antitank weapons that does not rely on armor. Passive systems use jamming and smoke to defeat missile guidance systems. Active systems use projectiles to shoot down the missile.

Amphibious vehicle
A vehicle that can swim across water as well as drive on land.

Antitank Guided Missile (ATGM)
Also known as ATGW (Antitank Guided Weapon). A term covering weapons intended to destroy tanks that can be controlled in flight by the firer. Guidance can take the form of radio, infrared imaging, laser homing, or even a length of wire connecting the missile to the launcher.

Appliqué armor
Add-on armor plates that can be mounted onto the hull or turret of an AFV to increase protection.

Armored car
A lightweight wheeled armored fighting vehicle used for reconnaissance and armed escort duties.

Armored Fighting Vehicle (AFV)
An armed and well-armored combat vehicle. Combining battlefield mobility, offensive capabilities, and armor protection, AFVs can include tanks, armored cars, troop carriers, amphibious vehicles, air defense vehicles, and self-propelled artillery.

Armored Personnel Carrier (APC)
A type of AFV designed to transport infantry to the battlefield, where they are dropped off to fight on their own. APCs are usually lightly armed and armored.

Armor Piercing (AP)
A type of ammunition that relies on its kinetic energy rather than explosive power to defeat armor. Types of AP ammunition include APC, APCBC, HVAP, APDS, and APFSDS.

Armor Piercing Capped (APC)
An Armor-Piercing round fitted with a softer cap to prevent the round from shattering on impact with armor plate.

Armor Piercing Capped Ballistic Cap (APCBC)
An APC round fitted with a thin aerodynamic nose cone to ensure its velocity remains high throughout its flight. The nose does not affect the round’s armor penetration ability.

Armor Piercing Discarding Sabot (APDS)
A projectile of a caliber smaller than that of the barrel in which it is fired, and so is carried by a casing or “sabot” inside the barrel. Once fired, the sabot falls away. APDS rounds have greater armor penetration than full-caliber projectiles.

Armor Piercing Fin Stabilized Discarding Sabot (APFSDS)
An APFSDS round uses the same design principle as APDS. Unlike APDS it does not spin and is stabilized by fins like a dart. APFSDS rounds are longer, travel faster, and can penetrate more armor than APDS. It is the most effective armor-piercing round used by modern tanks.

Armor Piercing High Explosive (APHE)
An AP round that contains a small explosive charge. This detonates after the round has penetrated the target’s armor, causing much more damage inside the tank than a conventional AP round.

Autoloader
A device designed to insert shells into the breech of the main gun of a tank. It replaces the loader, or crewman dedicated to loading the gun.

Automatic
A gun that continuously loads and fires while its trigger is pressed.

Ball mount
A spherical machine-gun mount usually located on the frontal plate of a tank’s hull. Unlike a fixed or coaxial mount, a ball mount moves independently of other weapons, giving the gunner greater flexibility when aiming. Ball mounts fell out of favor after World War II.

Bar armor
Also known as slat armor or cage armor, bar armor is a mesh of steel bars that is added to an AFV’s hull to protect it against RPGs.

Battalion
A military unit consisting of around 700 soldiers or 30–50 tanks. It is made up of companies or squadrons. Battalions can operate independently for limited periods.

Bogie
An arrangement of wheels, typically featuring two pairs.

Bore
The internal diameter of a gun barrel.

Bow
The front end of a tank.

Breacher vehicle
An armored vehicle outfitted with equipment such as a plough or dozer blade that is designed to drive through minefields, clearing a path for troops and vehicles.

Breech
The closed rear end of a gun’s barrel. It is opened to receive ammunition.

Bridge layer
Officially known as an Armored Vehicle-Launched Bridge (AVLB), a bridge layer is a combat support vehicle that can deploy and retrieve a removable metal bridge to enable tanks and other AFVs to cross rivers, craters, trenches, and other obstacles.

Bridging weight
The weight classification of a vehicle used to calculate what kind of bridge it can cross safely.

Brigade
A military unit made up of regiment- or battalion-size units. Its strength is usually around 5,000 soldiers.

Caliber
The internal diameter of a gun barrel. Since the 1950s this has almost always been expressed in millimeters (mm).

Canister shot
An antipersonnel round intended to give tanks and artillery protection from infantry. Canister rounds contain a large number of small, nonexplosive projectiles. When fired, the canister disintegrates, releasing the projectiles onto the enemy at high velocity.

Cartridge
A unit of ammunition consisting of a projectile and a brass or steel case containing its propellant.

Ceramic plate
A component of composite armor.

Chain gun
A machine gun or cannon that uses a motor-driven chain to power its moving parts, rather than gas or recoil from the fired round.

Chobham armor
Chobham armor is the unofficial name for a type of composite armor developed in the 1960s at the British tank research centre on Chobham Common, Surrey. It was designed to be particularly effective against shaped charges. Its elements remain a secret, but they are known to include ceramic tiles encased in metal mesh bonded to a backing plate with several elastic layers. Official names or different variants of Chobham include Burlington and Dorchester armor.

Christie suspension
A revolutionary type of tank suspension designed by American engineer J. Walter Christie in 1928. Each wheel was given its own suspension spring and an unprecedented freedom of vertical movement, thus enabling the vehicle to move at high speed over rough ground. Early versions had powered road wheels and could be driven without tracks.

Coaxial machine gun
A machine gun mounted on the same axis as a vehicle’s main gun. It is aimed using the same sights, and can be used if the main gun’s force is deemed excessive or inappropriate.

Column
A formation of tanks arranged one in front of another.

Combat engineer vehicle
An AFV used to transport combat engineers around the battlefield, often equipped with mine-breaching devices such as a bulldozer’s blade.

Combat weight
The total mass of a tank when fully equipped for the battlefield.

Command vehicle
A vehicle containing the facilities a commander needs to lead his unit. This can include multiple radios, map boards, and desk space for aides and staff officers.

Commander
The tank crewman responsible for commanding the tank. Depending on his seniority he may also be in command of other tanks and supporting arms.

Company
A military unit, normally equivalent in size to the squadron and consisting of around 150 soldiers or 14–18 tanks. “Company” was traditionally an infantry term.

Composite armor
A type of vehicle armor composed of different layers of material, such as metals, plastics, and ceramics.

Corps
A military unit, usually made up of several divisions, with a strength of 50,000 soldiers or more.

Counterinsurgency
Military operations aimed at defeating an enemy that does not operate as a distinct military force. The objective of counterinsurgency is generally political control and securing civilian support, rather than military victory. Counterinsurgency vehicles are usually armored against mines or IEDs, and are often wheeled to appear less threatening.